generous deal and that Papaji should take it. ‘Besides, a car is a car.’

‘I beg to differ, Your Highness,’ Papaji said. ‘The 1951 V-6 engine, the improved camshaft, the longer wheelbase, the massive 85 horsepower at 4000 rpm, all of it makes this car more than just another car. I apologize if I’m being imprudent, Your Highness, but I don’t want to buy any other car,’ Papaji said. ‘It’s okay if you can’t sell it.’ The maharaja stared at Papaji for a moment. I could hear the stewards whispering to each other. Papaji must have annoyed him, I thought. But the maharaja only smiled and continued to sip tea from his cup. Nobody talked about the car any more. I enjoyed a plate full of fruit cake, which was arranged for me on His Highness’s orders. The puppy ran around the garden carefree. After half an hour of this royal rendezvous, Papaji took his permission to leave. The humble Maharaja insisted on seeing us off. Just as we reached the gate, the maharaja asked out of the blue, ‘Do you really want to buy that car?’

‘I do,’ Papaji replied. ‘I’ll arrange for the payment. I can pay it in instalments but I will pay whatever the cost is.’

‘I can give it to you on one condition, and no questions will be asked,’ the maharaja said. Papaji waited for him to speak, and he continued, ‘I will take a payment of one rupee only.’ My jaw dropped. The maharaja looked at me and said, ‘And if you allow me to keep the puppy.’ Flabbergasted, I looked at Papaji, who nodded his approval. I kissed the puppy and passed it into the maharaja’s open hands. Papaji at once took out a one-rupee note from his wallet and handed it to the maharaja. ‘The car will reach your address tomorrow. This is the least I can do for our brave men in uniform who keep us all safe,’ a smiling maharaja said as he stroked the puppy’s head.

Papaji thanked him and we left. I was overwhelmed by the exceptional turn of events that I had just witnessed. A simple, plain and honest confrontation had reaped extraordinary results. And yet, the chances were taken with utmost sincerity—something I wasn’t ever going to forget. Over the next few years, we would undertake memorable long journeys in that wonderful car, along with our dogs. We would camp on the way whenever